

trading activity, engaging in smart planning, and by following some of the simple rules we outline in this book.

Perhaps you are skeptical that you can manage your own wealth. After all, legions of wealth managers have probably told you repeatedly that you cannot. We are here to tell you that you can. We have been lucky to work with and learn from some superb family offices, and the people that run their organizations. The main finding from our experience is that complexity does not imply value—especially when talking about investments.

Many less wealthy investors are told that the mega-rich benefit from their access to arcane strategies, hedge funds, and private equity investments. We are here to tell you that this popular and widespread meme has been propagated by salesmen, not by evidence: access to overpriced, opaque, complex, tax-inefficient exposures typically managed by egomaniacs is not an advantage—it is a serious disadvantage!

What matters in investing are avoiding psychology traps and sticking to the FACTS (fees, access, complexity, taxes, and search), a framework we describe in [Chapter 5](#). These simple concepts apply to everyone, not just the ultra-wealthy. The findings of this book are therefore applicable to the middle-class as well as to the mega-rich. Attempting to maintain and grow wealth accumulated over a lifetime is a task that is equally daunting for both individuals and for big name family offices.

Our natural inclination is to succumb to the challenge of portfolio management and let an “expert” deal with the problem. For a variety of reasons we discuss in this book, we should resist this urge to go with our gut instinct. We suggest that investors maintain direct control, or at least a thorough understanding, of how their hard-earned wealth is managed.

Our book is meant to be an educational journey that slowly builds confidence in one's own ability to manage a portfolio. In our book, we explore a potential solution that can be applicable to a wide-variety of investors, from the ultra-high-net-worth to middle-class individual, all of whom are focused on similar goals of preserving and growing their capital over time.